BUY-SIDE · DEAL SCREENING · PE PLAYBOOK

Kill 15 deals before lunch.

Businesses evaluated	20
Numbers checked	4
DEAD IN 90 SECONDS	15

Paul Baker

Founder, smbx.ai · 20+ years in M&A

SWIPE ›

SCREEN 1 · CONCENTRATION

One customer above 25% — kill.

Deal size	**$3.2M**
Concentration	**38% in one customer**
Days from close	**11**
What happened	**Customer left. SBA pulled.**
Sunk cost	**$60K**

SCREENS 2 + 3

Thin margins. Shrinking top line. Kill both.

Screen 2	**SDE margin below 15%**
Why	**$10K of buffer on a personal guarantee**
Screen 3	**Revenue declining 3+ quarters**
Why	**Paying peak for a shrinking asset**

SCREEN 4 · OWNER DEPENDENCY

Remove the owner. Does it still run?

IF THE OWNER DOES IT →

Every client relationship	**KILL**
Every sale	**KILL**
Every decision	**KILL**

You're not buying a company.
You're buying a job.

THE MATH

15 of 20 fail. You won’t know which 5 won’t.

PE associate: **90 seconds**. First-time buyer: **4 months and $50K**. Same answer.

FREE · 12 MINUTES

Pre-screen any deal with Baseline™.

Start at smbx.ai ›

No account required · Your data stays yours